

The first mammals

Small and furry, the first mammals looked like mice. They were warm-blooded, which means that their body temperature stayed the same whether it was hot or cold outside. Early mammals lived alongside the dinosaurs but avoided them by hiding in the day and being active only at night, when in the cool, dark air, they chased insects, worms, and other small animals.

Nemegtbaatar

nem-EGT-bat-or

- **When** 65 million years ago (Late Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Mongolia
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 4 in (10 cm)
- **Diet** Possibly plants

Nemegtbaatar looked a bit like a vole, with a similar short, deep skull, but it wasn't a close relative of voles. It had a wide snout, and its snout bones were riddled with tiny holes for blood vessels. Perhaps the extra blood flow supplied a special gland or a patch of sensitive skin on the top of its head. *Nemegtbaatar* is thought to have been a plant-eater. It had no canine teeth (fangs), and its front teeth (incisors) were large and jutting out, giving it a buck-toothed look.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features of mammals

- Females have glands that produce milk
- Body covered with fur or hair
- Ears contain tiny bones that evolved from the jaw bones of ancestors
- Four different types of tooth
- Teeth replaced only once during life

When

The first mammals appeared in the Late Triassic, 200 million years ago.

Teinolophos

TIE-nuh-LOW-fuss

- **When** 125 million years ago (Early Cretaceous)
- **Fossil location** Australia
- **Habitat** Woodlands
- **Length** 4 in (10 cm)
- **Diet** Insects

Only the lower jaw of *Teinolophos* has been found. Even so, scientists are fairly sure this small creature was related to the modern duckbilled platypus, the jaw of which shares key features with that of *Teinolophos*. Most modern mammals give birth to babies, but the duckbilled platypus is one of the few mammals that still lays eggs, as its reptilelike ancestors did. *Teinolophos* was an egg layer, too.



Teinolophos's jaw was tiny but it had a strong bite.

